

GETTY IMAGES

Over the past month and a half, Manipur has been seized by repeated cycles of violence, bloodletting and failed efforts at peace. Since May 3, when ethnic clashes first erupted in the northeastern state, 130 people have died, 352 have been injured and some 60,000 have had to flee their homes. The list under 'still counting'...over 4,300 incidents of arson, nearly 3,500 houses destroyed in around 275 villages, 4,000 firearms looted by violent mobs from police armouries. All this despite Manipur being under a heavy security blanket—the state has India's third-highest number of police personnel per 100,000 people; large parts of it are under the Armed Forces Special Powers Act (AFSPA), with 114 companies of various central forces deployed. To top it all, a 'double engine' regime—BJP governments at the Centre and the state—is in power. 'Triple engine' if you count the not-inconsiderable presence of one of the party's strongest leaders as a chief minister in the neighbourhood. And the Union home ministry (MHA) is constantly monitoring the situation.

So why is Manipur still burning? Because the entire state—from the administration to civil society—is ethnically split between the two warring communities, Meitei and Kuki, with a strong whiff of a tense religious binary overlaid on it. At every level, ethnic loyalties, in what has been a battle for land and existence, look to be preceding professional integrity within the administration. For instance, on May 4, when arms were looted from a police training centre and the camp of the 7th Manipur Rifles and 6th India Reserve battalion of Manipur police, all located in Pangei, a Meitei-dominated area in Imphal valley, similar scenes were witnessed in police stations and training centres in Churachandpur, a Kuki-majority district that very day. In either case, as multiple reports suggest, police guards—mostly Meiteis in Pangei and Kukis in Churachandpur—voluntarily facilitated the loot so that their respective communities

